

# UNITARIA

Book One: MISSING · Title

*“If you had everything you ever wanted, would you still want the truth?”*

In a world where phones have been replaced with LiFE wristbands that know your passion before you do, sixteen-year-old Ro has spent her life wondering if there’s something wrong with her. She has tried everything, searching for the thing that will prove she has a purpose — and somehow earned a place among forty Golden Prospects at the Academy.

At the Compass Ceremony, every student is placed into one of four Houses, the teams they’ll represent throughout the Academy year. But when Ro touches the golden Compass, it glitches live in front of the world.

For the first time, the system that tells everyone else who they are has no answer for her.

Ro throws herself into the Academy, determined to finally find her thing. But as the year builds towards the Exhibition — the spectacular final competition where the forty Prospects must show the world what they’ve discovered — Ro still has nothing to show. Until her search for an innovation leads her somewhere she was never meant to look.

And discovering the truth could cost her the first place she’s ever felt she belongs.

# The book in one table

|               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| TITLE         | MISSING · Book One title                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| SERIES        | MISSING · Series title (Unitaria?)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CATEGORY      | Young adult                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GENRE         | MISSING · Genre label                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| LENGTH        | MISSING · Target word count                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| POINT OF VIEW | MISSING · POV and tense                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| SETTING       | Neuropa, the capital, in 2077: the golden jubilee year, fifty years after the world was remade.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| OPENS         | End of August 2076, just before Ro starts her Academy year, with the reveal that her points are the fourth highest in the realm.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| TIMESPAN      | About eight months: the Academy year from September 2076, building to the opening of the Exhibition season on 7 May 2077. The Grand Final is Book Two's big show.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| LOGLINE       | Sixteen-year-old Ro has spent her life wondering if there's something wrong with her. When the golden Compass glitches as it places her into a House at the Academy, the system that tells everyone else who they are has no answer for her. Determined to prove there is something inside her, Ro sets out to find her purpose — only to discover that the truth about the system could cost her the first place she's ever felt she belongs. |
| HEART         | If you had everything you ever wanted, would you still want the truth?                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| COMPS         | MISSING · Comps                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

## Positioning

*The Hunger Games* asks what happens when entertainment becomes violence. Unitaria asks what happens when entertainment becomes governance.

*Black Mirror* asks what technology reveals about us. Unitaria asks what happens when technology makes a genuinely better world, and therefore makes giving it up almost impossible.

# Our world, with fifty more years of culture

Unitaria is not “the future”. It’s our world, if our culture had fifty more years to evolve.

The Academy is Oxford, Stanford, the Olympics, TikTok, a royal institution and reality television rolled into one. The houses are college sports with mascots in arena suits. The Director is a celebrity and a human platform. Technology doesn’t remove silliness. It gives silliness a production budget.

So the reader wants in first: *I’d love to go to the Academy. I want to know my house. I want the band. I want to meet the Director.* Then, gradually: *oh. Oh no. I actually understand why everyone stays.*

## The rule Book One lives by

The world is never obviously sinister. The romance is romantic, the houses are genuinely exciting, the Exhibition is genuinely spectacular, and Unitaria is genuinely better than our world in some ways. When the cracks appear, the reader doesn’t think “get out!” They think “but I don’t want this world to disappear either.”

## What she sees every day

### The LiFE band

Convenience, no screens, a life assistant that knows you. Underneath: constant surveillance and emotional nudging.

### The points

No money, no fines, every right free. But the basics are grey, and colour, flavour and wonder are paid upgrades. Children earn for their families.

### The Academy

One guaranteed year for every sixteen-year-old, broadcast to the world. Forty Golden Prospects, four houses, and the Exhibition at the end of it.

### The houses

Polaris, Aurora, Lyra and Orion, chosen by the golden Compass. Teams to root for and a show nobody can stop watching.

# Ro, sixteen

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| HER NAME         | Ro, short for Rosalia. She hates her full name, and nobody uses it except the Director, who always calls her Rosalia.                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| WHO              | Sixteen in 2077, born in 2061, after the world was remade. She lives on the crescents in Neuropa, quiet-luxury terraces with tall hedges, with Harry's clubhouse hidden in the topiary.                                                                                                                    |
| HER WOUND        | Everyone around her seems so happy and content, except her. Parentified by an absent dad and a checked-out mum, she wonders whether she isn't just unhappy, but bad. Three layers deep: everyone else seems to know how to be a person except me; maybe there's something wrong with me; I want to matter. |
| HER DAD'S SHADOW | Her dad is one of the Seven, so everyone asks, kindly and genuinely confused, "So what's your thing?" In a world where the system works, she assumes she is the malfunction.                                                                                                                               |
| HER PLACE        | She tried every single job, not to get ahead but to find a passion, and without realising racked up a ridiculous number of points. The girl with no passion is chosen as one of the forty Golden Prospects.                                                                                                |
| HER DIFFERENCE   | Her band was quietly altered by Grandpapa Harry, so it lags and can't read her excitement. The system that serves everyone their passion can't see hers. When she touches the golden Compass, it goes haywire for one second, live, in front of the world.                                                 |
| HER FLAW         | She wants validation. She has ambition: she wants to be respected and to have a name people recognise, so she buys into the exact system that will eventually hurt her.                                                                                                                                    |
| HER DANGER       | Her readings are normal. Her curiosity is not.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| PERSONALITY      | <b>MISSING · Voice and personality</b> (deliberately left open for now)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| HER HOUSE        | Not Orion, because Jase is her Orion rival. <b>MISSING · Polaris, Aurora or Lyra</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| HER WANT         | To prove there was something in her all along, and to become someone worth respecting.                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| HER CHOICE       | The life where she belongs, or the truth that proves why she never did.<br><b>MISSING · What she decides</b>                                                                                                                                                                                               |

## Why her story comes first

Nonna remembers the world before. Her mum stays silent. She inherits a world she never saw being made. She lives inside the world's greatest success story, and she is the one who can't understand why everyone else seems so happy.

# What the Bible already fixes, in order

|                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>END OF AUGUST 2076</b>  | Just before her Academy year: her points are revealed as the fourth highest in the realm. Four Golden Prospects go from each realm, so she takes the last place. The girl with no passion only just makes it in. No child knows their score until sixteen.                                                                             |
| <b>AT SIXTEEN</b>          | The moment she turns sixteen, her younger brother becomes the family's main child earner.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>WEEKS BEFORE</b>        | One of her friends opts into the Recalibrate beta, with mapping and automatic location sharing pitched as finding new spots for community projects.                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>SEPTEMBER 2076</b>      | The Academy year begins at once. The Compass Ceremony sorts the forty into four houses of ten, one from every realm. The Compass goes haywire when she touches it.                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>GRATITUDE PARADE</b>    | The Thanksmas draw: the Director picks each realm's week live. Cariberia comes first; Neuropa is week 10.                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>7 MAY 2077</b>          | The 50th Reconnection Day and her dad's fiftieth birthday. Recalibrate, a gentle mood-ring update, is announced in passing. The Exhibition season opens: every Academy student in the world submits, and each realm votes its top ten through with points to exhibit around the Academy's event space. The stage belongs to the forty. |
| <b>THE END OF BOOK ONE</b> | Nonna dies. In her grief Ro sings the lullaby, hears "My child, seek and you shall find", and remembers the safe. <b>MISSING · Exactly when, around 7 May</b>                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>THE LAST SCENE</b>      | Ro reads the letter in the safe: "My dearest..., if you're reading this, and I hoped you never would in your lifetime, it means you need to hear it." Her grandparents updated it every year until she was five, then stopped. Beside it, a hard drive the size of a USB stick and young Nonna's diary, waiting for Book Two.          |
| <b>BOOK TWO</b>            | The Exhibition season itself: the realm weeks, the World's Fair Grand Final as the big show, Recalibrate rolling out to every band, and Placement Day.                                                                                                                                                                                 |

## MISSING STORY BEATS

The months between the Compass Ceremony and 7 May · what she finds at the Academy, and how · the Exhibition opening · what she decides.

The feeling on the last page is already fixed: enraged, awakened, needing to know more, satisfied but shaken, and "it's ON."

# “I desperately want this world to be right about me”

Her problem isn't that she dislikes the world. It's that she wants it to be right about her, and the Academy looks like the answer.

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| BEGINNING        | Something is wrong with me.                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DESIRE           | I want to prove there isn't.                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ARRIVAL          | Maybe the Academy can finally tell me who I am.                                                                                                                                                              |
| DISCOVERY        | Look at everything I can do! She is free, everyone says “sure”, and she has the time of her life: friends, love, house obsession, late nights.                                                               |
| EXPLORATION      | Maybe it's this. No. Maybe it's this. Still no. No lightning bolt, yet she is quietly becoming incredibly capable.                                                                                           |
| PANIC            | Everyone else is finding their thing and becoming known. She still has nothing.                                                                                                                              |
| EXHIBITION       | Show the world what you found. She hasn't found it, and this is the final exam on “Is there actually something inside me?”                                                                                   |
| MYSTERY          | Hunting for an innovation, she finds something she wasn't supposed to. How does the Academy know what people are meant to do? What happens to people it can't place? <b>MISSING · What exactly she finds</b> |
| REVELATION       | Maybe I'm not failing the system. Maybe the system can't actually see me.                                                                                                                                    |
| CRISIS           | If I expose this, I could lose everything I've finally found.                                                                                                                                                |
| EXHIBITION OPENS | The life where I belong, or the truth that proves why I never did.<br><b>MISSING · What happens on the night</b>                                                                                             |
| GRIEF            | Nonna dies. The lullaby leads her to the safe.                                                                                                                                                               |
| END              | She reads Nonna's letter: “I hoped you never would.” “I don't know what I'm going to become. But I know nobody else gets to decide for me.”                                                                  |

**The heart:** her lack of passion is her first genuine act of individuality. She thinks it proves she's broken. By the end, it proves she was free.

# Who she has, and who she's up against

## Nonna

Born 1994, remembers the world before. Living under a new identity, band deactivated and worn as a ruse. Nags about recipes and hums the kneading song: "palms up and down, round and round." Dies at the end of Book One. Real name:

MISSING · Nonna's real name

## Grandpapa Harry

Died recently. Altered her band and left a clubhouse that is a dead zone. Never fully explained, on purpose.

## Dad · MISSING · Name

Mostly absent. Works for the Director and is one of the Seven, born with the new world on 7 May 2027. Turns fifty on 7 May 2077, Reconnection Day.

## Mum · MISSING · Name

Knows the family safe exists and has no interest in what's inside.

## Brother · MISSING · Name

Younger. Becomes the family's main child earner the moment she turns sixteen.

## Nell and Sam

Her best friends: Nell, short for Renella, and Samson, always Sammy to her. Nell is desperately in love with Sammy; he has no clue, and Ro only half suspects. One of them is already in the Recalibrate beta. MISSING · Which one

## Jase and Sam

**The Spark:** Jase, her Orion nemesis. Rivals first, then something real. He meets the girl she's becoming and makes her feel alive. **The Anchor:** Sam, always Sammy, her oldest friend and home. He makes her feel known. The Sam moment waits for Book Two.

## Chosen family

MISSING · Who they are

## Director Benedict Reverington

A celebrity and human platform. Sunglasses, the snow leopard mascot behind him, a stadium that erupts when he waves. He notices her when the Compass glitches. "It's Ro." "Which is short for Rosalia, isn't it, Rosalia." He walks away. Charming, funny, may even care about her, and still the man who built the machine: not secretly evil, just himself all along.

## The other Golden Prospects

Forty in all, ten per house, one from every realm.

MISSING · Named rivals and allies

# Jase makes her feel alive. Sam makes her feel known.

Not simply a love triangle: two versions of Ro's life, arriving at different stages of her becoming.

## Jase · the Spark

Her Orion nemesis and her first real romance. He meets the new Ro, the girl just discovering she might be capable of far more. He doesn't tell her she's good enough; he pushes her.

Nemeses, rivalry, forced proximity, grudging respect, friendship and attraction, "why are you actually fun?", romantic tension, something real.

*"You don't actually want to find your thing."*

*"What?" "You want everyone to think you're worth something."* She hates him for seeing it, because he's right.

## Sam · the Anchor

Her oldest friend. Everyone has always called him Sammy. He knows the Ro who existed before she started trying to reinvent herself. In Book One he is home and continuity, and the romantic shift doesn't happen yet.

**The Sam moment (Book Two):** she walks into Harry's clubhouse expecting Sammy and sees Sam, grown and more himself. Just "oh." "Ro?" "What?" "Are you alright?" "Yeah." She looks away.

### JASE STANDS FOR

The new Ro, the Academy, ambition, competition, risk, discovery, becoming. Being seen by someone who met her after she began changing.

### SAM STANDS FOR

The old Ro, home, history, safety, being known, chosen family. The person who knew her before she had to prove herself.

### THE NAME

Sammy is the boy she never had to question. Sam is the person who grew while she wasn't looking. "When did you become someone I hadn't noticed before?"

### NELL'S SECRET

Nell is desperately in love with Sammy. He has no clue, and Ro only half suspects, because Nell either acts weird or instantly recovers.

### THE REAL QUESTION

Not "who will Ro choose?" but "who is Ro when she isn't trying to become someone other people approve of?" The answer can't be Jase, Sam, the Academy, her father or the Director. It has to be Ro.

Neither boy is obviously better: "Jase makes her feel alive" against "Sam actually knows her", and neither side is wrong.

**MISSING · Ro's house (not Orion)**

# The engines already in place

|                |                                                                                                                                         |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| THE CLOCK      | The Academy year, counting down to the Exhibition opening on 7 May, the jubilee and her dad's fiftieth.                                 |
| THE THREAT     | Recalibrate, hidden as an advert. It adds mapping and location sharing, and her lagging band could be exposed by it.                    |
| BEING WATCHED  | The Compass glitch happened live, in front of the world, and the Director saw it.                                                       |
| THE FRIEND     | Her friend is already mapped by the beta, so the one safe place can be found through someone she loves.                                 |
| THE SAFE PLACE | Harry's clubhouse, a dead zone hidden in the topiary.                                                                                   |
| THE SONG       | Nonna's kneading song. Its movements open the family safe, and Polaris's motto, "Seek, and you shall find", is its first line.          |
| THE ROMANCE    | Jase makes her feel alive; Sam makes her feel known. Neither is wrong, and neither gets to define her. <b>MISSING · How it develops</b> |

## FOR YOU, NOT THE BUYER · WHAT SITS UNDERNEATH

The bands are secretly radiation exposure meters, a number like a nuclear worker's dosimeter, not a diagnosis. People whose readings climb too high are quietly removed to Isola. Book One only lets the reader feel the edge of this: people who seem "not themselves" have a way of disappearing, so everyone learns to smile. **MISSING · How it develops in Book One**

## Seeds planted for later books

Nonna's recipes ("the most valuable thing you own, my girl") · the kneading song and the safe · Orion's hidden wall of names · Rehoming, and why people never seem to come home · Nonna's diary as a cipher manual.

# Where the Bible argues with itself

**Where the book opens: settled.** End of August 2076, with the points reveal; the Academy year starts in September; the book builds to the Exhibition opening, and the Grand Final moves to Book Two. Knock-ons: Ro's birthday must fall before late August, and the Recalibrate beta's "a few weeks before the story" needs re-dating.

**Why she's chosen.** The Bible has her chosen on points from trying every job, and also mentions an entry or submission at fifteen. Submissions have already been removed from the public site.

**Where she spends the year.** The Grand Academy is in Neuropa, but the realm weeks and mixed campuses suggest the forty travel. Which home base do readers see most?

**Sam's trust.** One note gives her male best friend a trust fund, but canon now says there is no children's trust: the under-16 share goes to the Academy.

## 10 · MISSING PIECES CHECKLIST

### BLOCKING THE PITCH

- Book One title
- What she finds, and how
- The Exhibition opening, and exactly when Nonna dies
- Comps
- Genre label, word count, POV

### IMPORTANT FOR THE MANUSCRIPT

- Ro's house (not Orion)
- Sam's age and where he spends the year
- Chosen family and named Prospects
- Mum, Dad and brother's names, and Nonna's real name
- Her house
- What she decides, and her Placement offer

### CAN WAIT

- Series title
- Her personality and voice (left open on purpose)